

How to win at DRP Workshop

Friday 20 March 2026

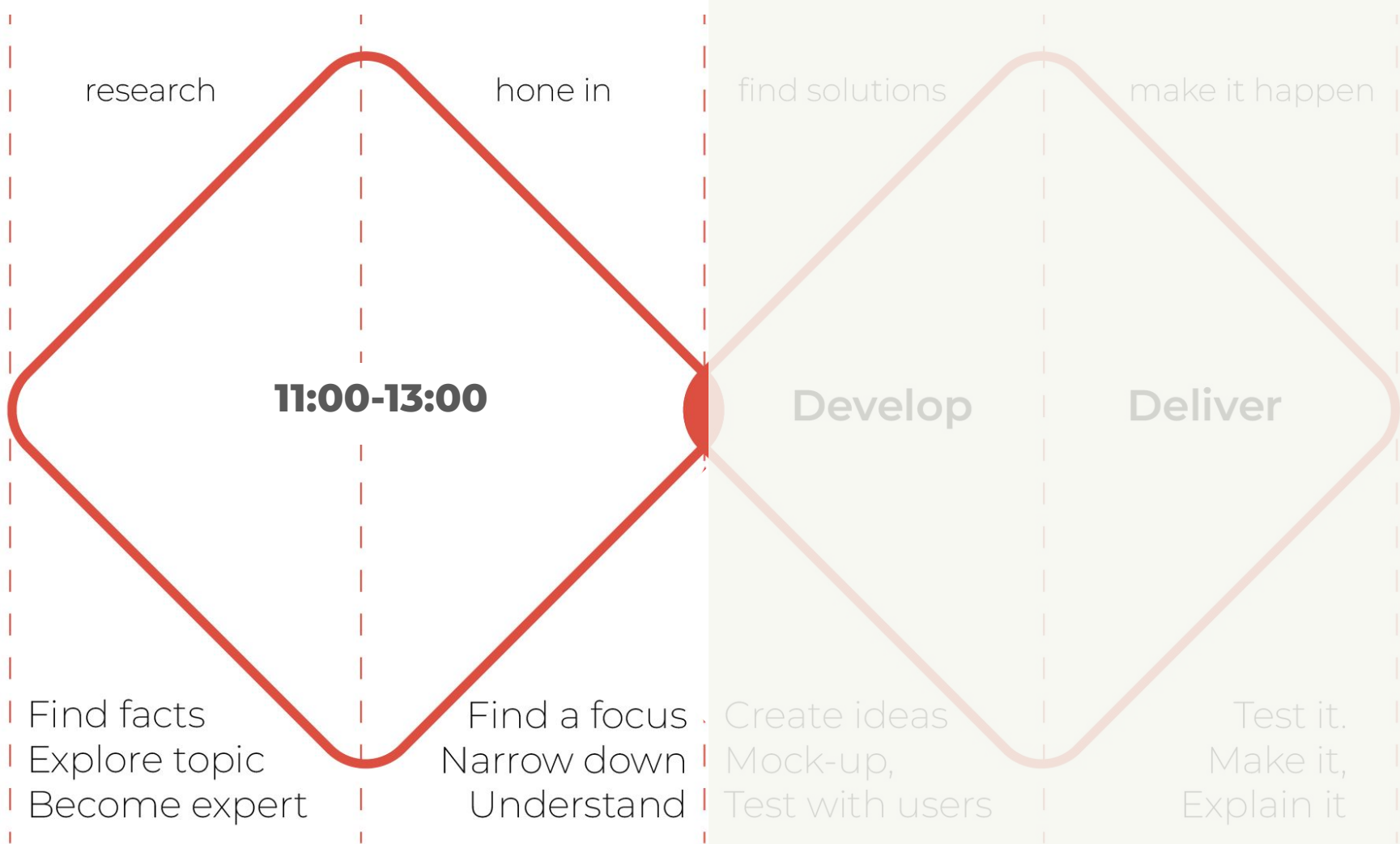
Clare Brass, Carolyn Runcie
(and seven talented service design Masters students from the Royal College of Art)

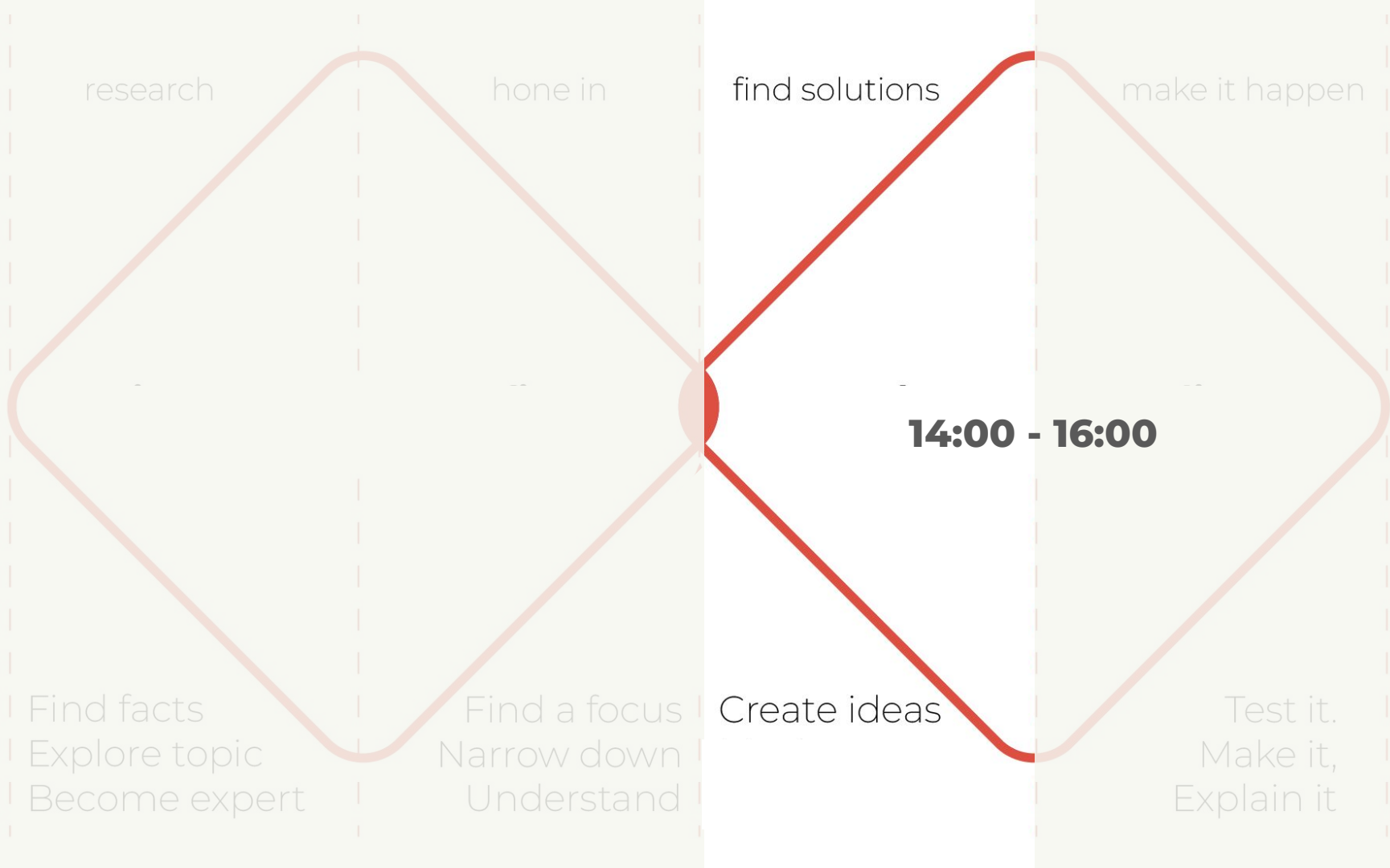
Tips for how to win the best project of the year

- Choose a theme that really interests you
- Talking to people
- Start with a problem, not an idea



Conversations with families at Tate, 2025 - RCA SD team project





Exploring a brief

You have already chosen a topic:

1. **What a waste!** 215 million tonnes of waste is produced in the U.K each year (Waste Direct 2024).
2. **Roundabout** London's workers spend 107 hours commuting annually, more if they have disabilities [Gov.uk, 2017]
3. **Ker-ching** Nearly 60% of UK parents have to help their adult kids, ages 18 to 34, with financial support. [[pewresearch.org](https://www.pewresearch.org), 2024]

EXERCISE 1

CREATING A COVER STORY POSTER

Understanding and communicating the problem to others

(20 minutes)

Exercise 1: Cover story poster about your topic: (20 mins)

Headline

How will you capture the essence of your cover story

Key stats

Include references eg
93% of disabled Londoners say their impairments limit their ability to travel and get about [TfL 2012]

A sketch, image or illustration

Bring the problem to life

The people - who's affected?

Eg 23% young adults aged 18-24 have credit card debts. Men are likely to hold more debt than women of the same age (men - £3,165, women - £1,882). [Tesco bank 2024]

STOP FOOD WASTE

1/3 of all food produced globally is wasted,
that's about 33%!



Sharp rise in type 2 diabetes among people under 40 in UK

Diagnoses up 39% in six years, with condition fuelled by
obesity, health inequalities and junk food, study finds



📷 New figures show there are 168,000 type 2 diabetes cases among the under-40s. Photograph: Maskot/Getty Images

The number of people under 40 being diagnosed with type 2 diabetes in the UK has risen 39% in six years, fuelled by soaring obesity levels and cheap junk food.

Britain has one of the highest obesity rates in Europe. Two in three adults are overweight or obese and the NHS spends £6bn a year treating obesity-related

12.1 million

UK adults live with diabetes or prediabetes



One in Five adults now live
with diabetes or prediabetes in UK

www.diabetes.org.uk

3,230

Cases of heart failure
caused weekly

(Diabetes UK, 2024)



£14B

Cost of Diabetes
Care to the NHS annually

(University of York, 2024)

£39B

Projected cost to
economy by 2035

(York, 2025)

FEEDBACK

10 mins

EXERCISE 2: Explain the issues through the stories of real people

Glenda



- Mid 70's
- Walks with difficulty
- Lives alone
- Community oriented,
- Loves art

Sophie



- Single mum, 32
- Lives in a flat, no lift
- Son is Sam, 3 months
- Works for a charity
- Struggling to cope

Matt



- 25
- Couldn't hold a job
- Substance abuse
- Forced to leave home
- Struggling to find shelter and work

Exercise 2: The main character (please: No Bobs or Alices!!)



“ I hate the waste created by my kids: they grow out of their clothes and shoes so fast - and they are almost perfect! I wish I knew someone who could make good use of them ”

Name
Sam Wright



32



Camberwell, London



Marketing executive



Lives with girlfriend and twin sons

Bio

Rented accommodation, too expensive, commutes daily to central London, plays hard at weekends, loves sport & fitness; loves to play with the kids; after hours, usually chills on the sofa with a glass of wine and a movie.

wants and needs

- Wants to do his bit for the planet
- Loves being out and about
- Wishes he had more time to socialise

Tech

Internet	● ● ● ● ●
Social media	● ● ● ● ○
Online shopping	● ● ● ● ○
Gadgets	● ● ● ● ●
Mobile phone	● ● ● ● ○
Home phone	● ○ ○ ○ ○
Early adopter	● ● ● ○ ○

Favourite brands



fairphone

VANS

Frustrations

- Wishes he had more time for family and to socialise
- Frustrated by local policies
- Hates waste
- Wants to reduce his costs

EXERCISE 2: WHO'S AT THE HEART OF THIS ISSUE?

Tell us about the person who lives with your challenge



Steve Dennison (40) Office Admin

"I followed the recommended changes for sometime but later, became inconsistent"

London, UK

Caribbean

Pre-Diabetic

Affordability conscious

Deprived neighbourhood

Pains

Struggles with stress, and unhealthy habits shaped by convenience and routine. Overwhelmed from health info available.

Fears

Health will worsen like others in his family, he's also anxious about the cost, and whether making changes will really help.

Goals & Needs

Manage his health without disrupting his routine. He needs affordable, culturally relevant solutions that are simple, clear, and sustainable across physical, mental, social, and economic aspects of health.



EXERCISE 2: SUGGESTED TEMPLATE - WHO'S AT THE HEART OF THIS ISSUE? (20 mins)

*create your own persona on your giant post-it sheet

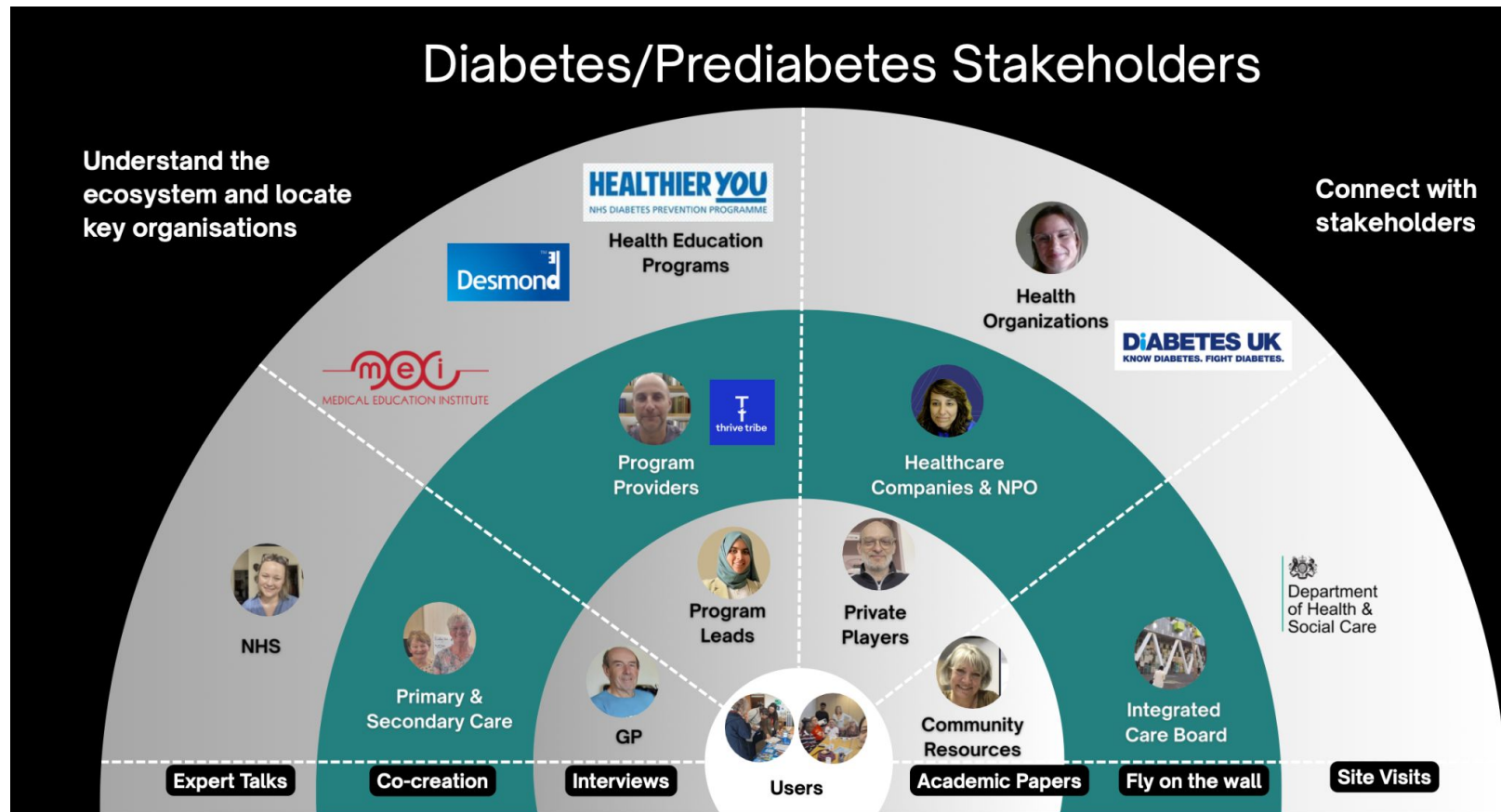
Photo/sketch/image of your user here	Name	Tech														
		<table><tr><td>Internet</td><td>○ ○ ○ ○ ○</td></tr><tr><td>Social media</td><td>○ ○ ○ ○ ○</td></tr><tr><td>Online shopping</td><td>○ ○ ○ ○ ○</td></tr><tr><td>Gadgets</td><td>○ ○ ○ ○ ○</td></tr><tr><td>Mobile phone</td><td>○ ○ ○ ○ ○</td></tr><tr><td>Home phone</td><td>○ ○ ○ ○ ○</td></tr><tr><td>Early adopter</td><td>○ ○ ○ ○ ○</td></tr></table>	Internet	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Social media	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Online shopping	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Gadgets	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Mobile phone	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Home phone	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	Early adopter	○ ○ ○ ○ ○
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Early adopter	○ ○ ○ ○ ○															
   	Bio	Favourite brands														
	wants and needs	Frustrations														

// Write what your user thinks/feels/ wish for here //

FEEDBACK

10 mins

Exercise 3: Who else is involved?



Exercise 3: Who else is involved?

No-one exists in complete isolation

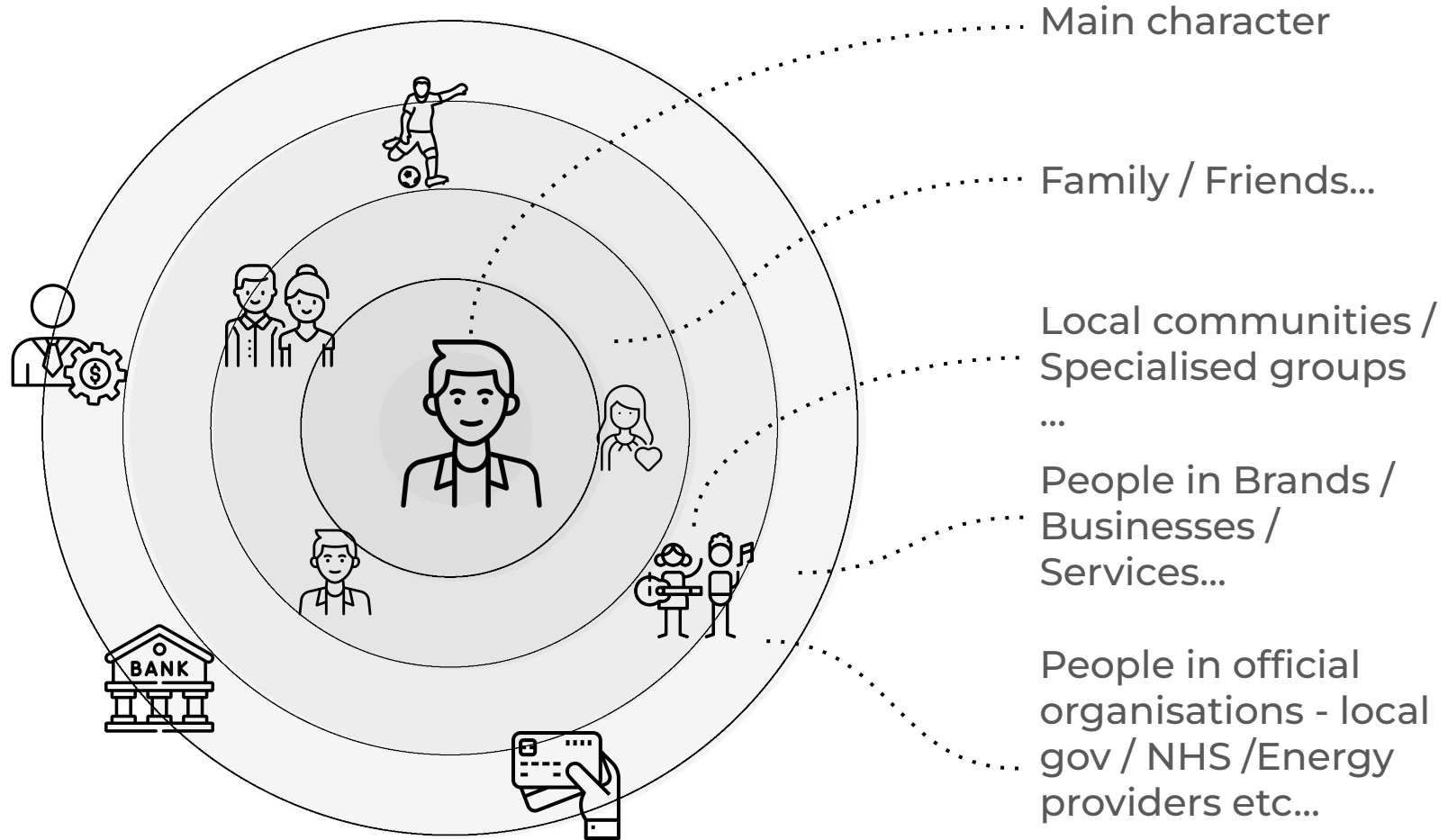
Who are the **other relevant people** that will appear?

Eg **What a waste!** - waste disposal operators / bin providers / packaging companies / supermarkets etc

Eg **mobility** - family / neighbours/friends / carers /doctors / public transport operators etc

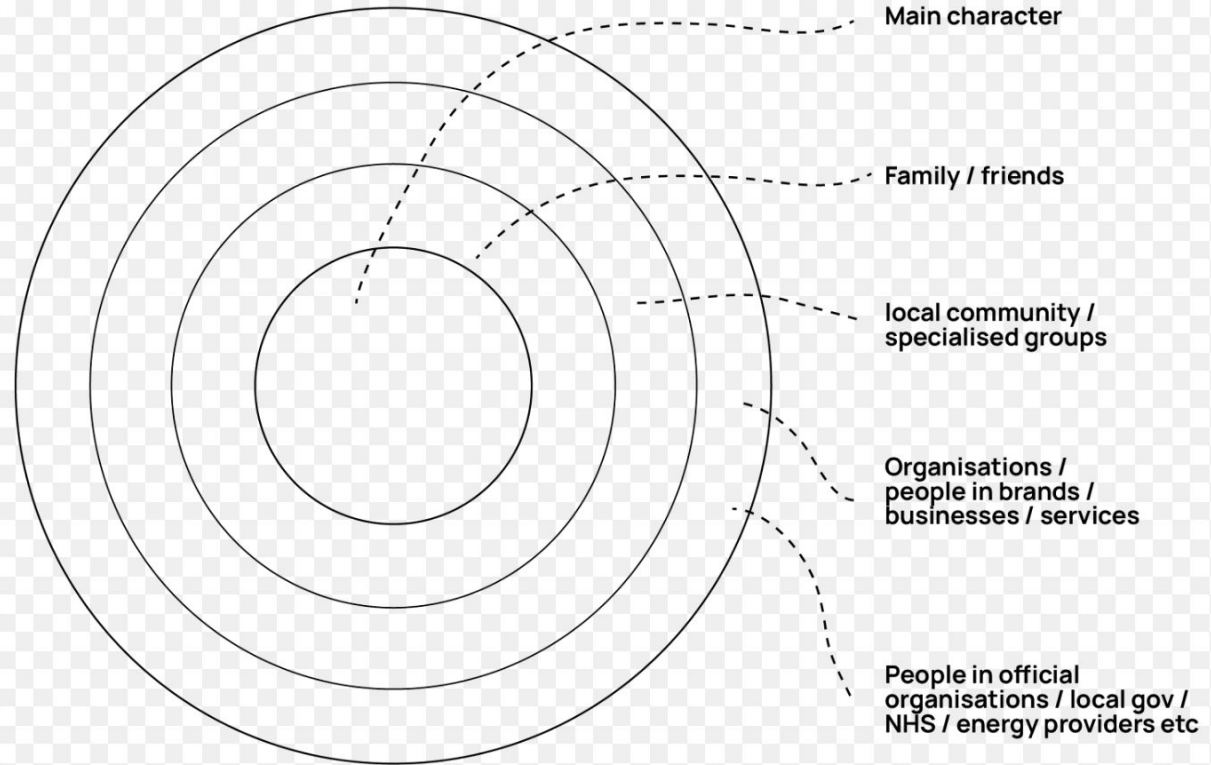
Eg **Ker-ching** - eg influencers / banks / parents / advertising

Exercise 3: Who else is involved?



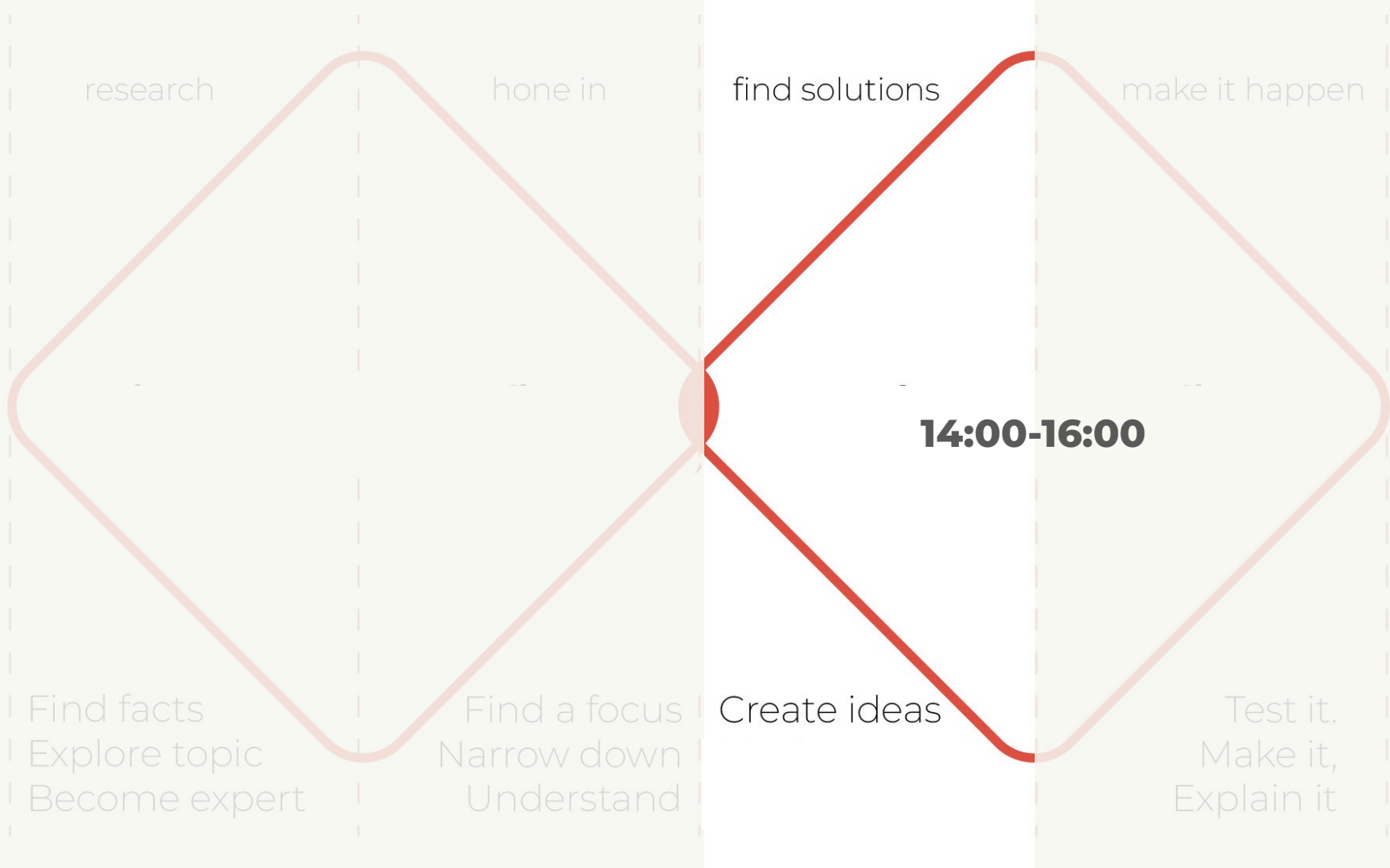
Exercise 3: Who else is involved? (20 mins)

- Draw 4 concentric circles on your large post-it sheet and map out different stakeholders
- Map out the critical players around the main character



FEEDBACK

10 mins

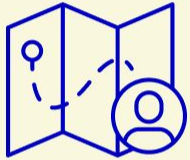


Lunch break (13:00-14:00)



Exercise 4: Mapping the user experience

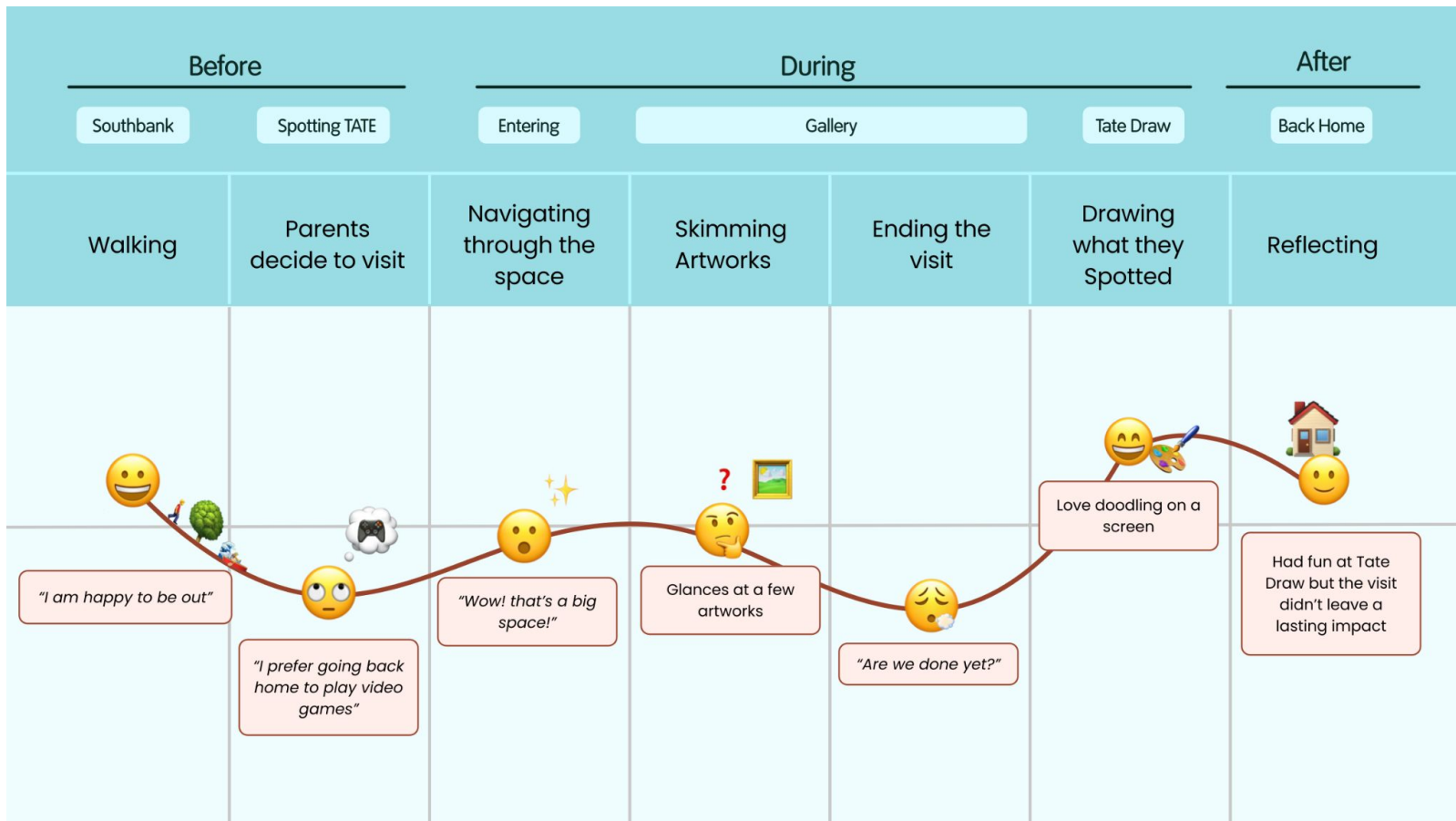
Journeys & Touchpoints



- 01 Metaphor that allows us to **chart the user experience**, as opposed to process mapping
- 02 Through this we can identify **overlap/gaps and highs/lows**
- 03 Opens up the possibility to **discuss opportunities with users**
- 04 **Steps by time**, running left to right. Before, during and after

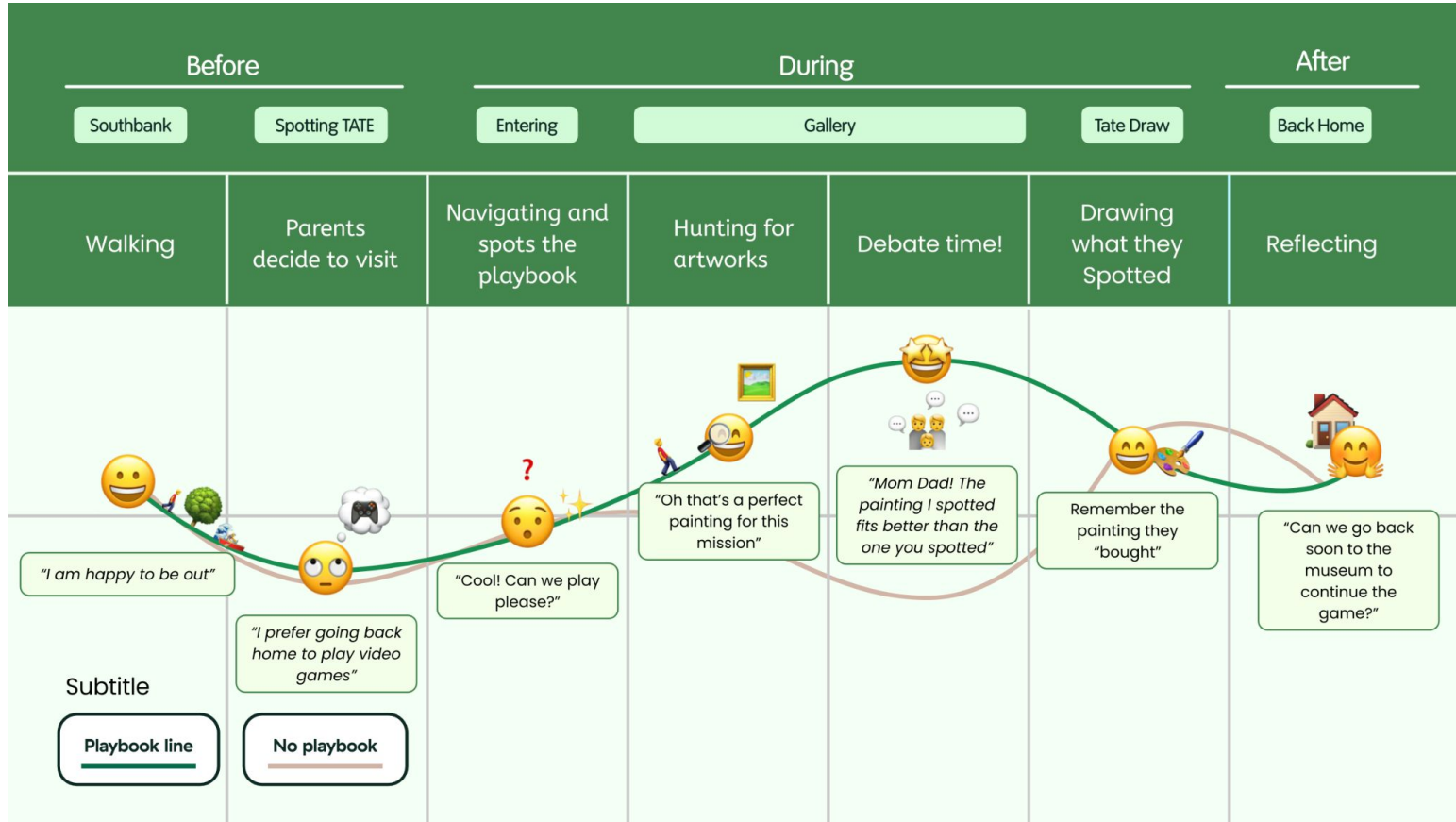
Exercise 4: Mapping the user experience ...

Understanding
the current
experience



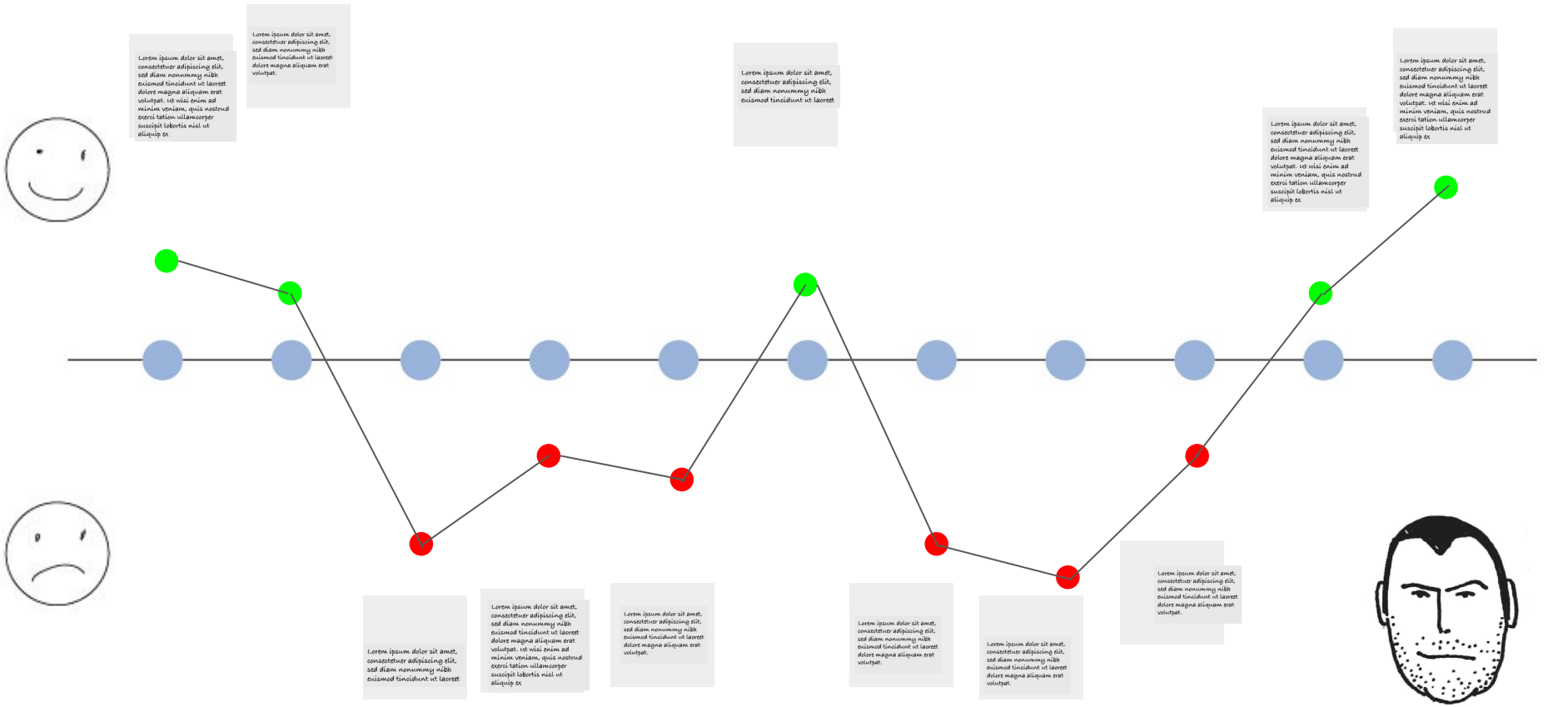
Exercise 4: Mapping the user experience ...

Highlighting
where
intervening in
the journey to
create a richer
experience



Exercise 4 cont: Charting the user experience... (20 mins)

What are the high/low points for your character in this journey?



FEEDBACK

10 mins

EXERCISE 5 - “I wish...”



**Worried
&
Anxious**



**No clarity or
knowledge for
next step**

RCA service design student project about pre-diabetes, 2025

“I wish I knew how I could change my eating habits to become healthier whilst enjoying the what I eat.”



EXERCISE 5 - "I wish..."

What a waste

Jack, interior decorator, Peckham: *"I waste about $\frac{1}{3}$ of the money I spend on materials because I have to over-order."*



*I wish there was a way of enabling other local people to buy those materials off me **so that** I didn't have to go to the dump every week."*

Roundabout

Penny, wheelchair user, Brent Cross. *"It takes me an hour and a half to get to my place of work in Kingsbury because there are no lifts at the connecting station."*



*I wish there was a way of going by car **so that** I could get there faster."*



Ker-ching

Sahil, 24, Ealing, just started new job.

"Even though I have a job, I still don't have any money at the end of the month. I hate asking my dad for money, but there's just no other way."

*I wish there was a way of saving a bit each month **so that** I could finally buy a guitar."*

EXERCISE 5 - “I wish...” (10 mins)

Thinking of the low points in the experience of your character, go back to the magic wand on the main character template and complete the following statement:

“I wish there was a way to...

...so that ...”



FEEDBACK ON “I WISH...”

10 mins

EXERCISE 5 - generating ideas based on “I wish...” (30 mins)



Exercise 6: Generate loads of ideas based on “I wish...”

(20 mins)

Giant post it note



	Idea
	Short description
Idea	Idea
Short description	Short description
Idea	Idea
Short description	Short description
Idea	Idea
Short description	Short description

Exercise 6a:

Choose the best idea (or combo of ideas)

(5 mins)

Giant post it note



	Idea
	Short description
Idea	Idea
Short description	Short description
Idea	Idea
Short description	Short description
Idea	Idea
Short description	Short description

FEEDBACK

(5 mins)

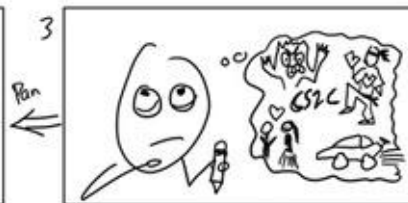
EXERCISE 7 - Develop your ideas using a Storyboard (20 mins)



Establishing shot of classroom.
One student snoring. One sits up
in alarm over assignment.



Student feels overwhelmed.
Voiceover: "I've never done this!"
Camera pans slowly to make space.



Ideas surrounded by blurry thought
bubble. Brainstorm may also be video
montage surrounded by blurry frame.



Moment of clarity. "Aha!"
Ding or chimes; lightbulb moment.



Working in a dark dorm room.
Sounds of clock ticking and pencil
scratching on paper.



Proudly shows off finished
storyboard. Wipes sweat off brow.
Victory music. Zoom in on storyboard.



Submitting via Coursework.
Fade out as if ending.



Back to the classroom. Keep as
similar as possible to original.
"Elaborate on your storyboards!"



Back to the drawing board.
Looking haggard but determined.
Fade out.

FEEDBACK

(10 mins)

Don't forget to Design for Real People

Throughout your DRP project, focus on the following:

- Who is the user?
- What are they trying to do (what are their needs)?
- What challenges are they facing? Why?
- What ideas do you have to solve these challenges
- How have you transformed the user experience?

Find a good topic to focus on in your DRP project



SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS

17 GOALS TO TRANSFORM OUR WORLD

aka: list of
Wicked Problems



Playbook to support your project

DESIGN FOR REAL PEOPLE

Playbook

About this playbook

This Playbook is a tool to support you on your research and design journey.

The four stages can offer guidance from starting your research process to delivering your final project solution.

The templates/tools are suggestions for ways of working, but you can develop your own that are best suited to your project's needs.

Thank you

Good luck in your exams

See you in May!

Tidying up:

Put post-its and pens in the box at the front

Dispose of your worksheets